
The World Cup's Ticketing Nightmare Is Finally Here

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Last Christmas, Jeremy Wright gave his soccer-loving wife a monumental present: tickets to the Netherlands–Japan World Cup matchup on June 14 at AT&T Stadium in Arlington, Texas. Purchased in September via StubHub, with taxes and platform fees included, the two passes nearly amounted to \$1,400—all before factoring in logistical expenses like gas for the drive from Austin, along with lodgings at a nearby hotel. Still, when game day arrived, Wright and his wife were all set to go, except for one major wrinkle: They never got the tickets.

Five hours before kickoff, after spending the morning celebrating with fellow fans before attending the team parade, Wright received an email from StubHub informing him that his tickets couldn't be transferred. When he opened the app, he was prompted to select "alternative tickets," only to find that none were available. He then requested a refund but encountered a confusing series of prompts that required him to enter his credit card information again. When he called customer service, he said, a representative repeatedly told him that because he had selected the refund option, they could no longer assist him. "I kept asking to talk to a manager," Wright told me. "To which they said, 'We can put it in a queue and someone will call you back in 24 hours.'"

By the time Wright and I spoke last week, he still hadn't gotten a callback. As for how he and his wife ultimately spent game day, "we were so disappointed that we drove four hours home in the rain and didn't watch the match." (A spokesperson for StubHub informed me, and Wright confirmed, that company reps offered him free hospitality-suite tickets to a semifinals game in Dallas–Fort Worth on July 14, after my request for comment from the company.)

Throughout this euphoric, [dramatic](#) World Cup series, which has brought [domestic and international tourists](#) to [North American cities](#) from Vancouver all the way down to Monterrey, there has been one unfortunate motif: fans unable to access the pricey tickets that they purchased in advance, whether through StubHub or SeatGeek or FIFA's [official ticketing platform](#). Many of the aggrieved fans I spoke with had chosen StubHub in particular, as it [commands a larger share](#) of the customer-to-customer resale market and represents a *chance*, at least, to get something cheaper than [what FIFA would allow](#). Or so it seemed, until they finally tried it for themselves and saw their purchases disappear altogether.

"I get claustrophobic in large gatherings, so I chose StubHub over SeatGeek because they let you pick seats," Thom Fountain, a Twin Cities–based sporting enthusiast, told me of his experience buying tickets for Thursday's Netherlands–Tunisia match in Kansas City. "But they sent me a completely different seat in the middle of the section, and when I reached out they told me my only recourse was to resell the tickets or keep them." The replacement tickets ended up cutting Fountain off from his refund opportunity, as per the terms of StubHub's "[FanProtect Guarantee](#)," which leaves decisions on resolutions to the platform's "sole discretion."

There are countless other soccer spectators with stories similar to Wright's and Fountain's—of getting secondhand tickets not worth the price initially paid, or of not receiving tickets at all thanks to

[seller cancellations](#) or transfer glitches, while seeing no relief from customer-service inquiries. (In fact, many unhappy fans are now talking to [neighborhood reporters](#) instead of sales reps.) The volume of complaints across [Facebook](#), [LinkedIn](#), and [local news desks](#) has swelled rapidly over the past month. While there is no hard data available yet on just how many tickets have been “sold” on one resale platform over another—such as Vivid Seats, which has also fielded [World Cup ticketing issues](#)—it makes sense that StubHub is getting the [most public attention](#): It’s the [most used resale app](#) in the world, and it has historically been the subject of [far more Better Business Bureau complaints](#) than any of [its competitors](#). (StubHub’s [profile page](#) on the bureau’s website, which gives it an “F” rating, has been flooded with [thousands of negative user comments](#) since June 2023—far exceeding SeatGeek and Vivid Seats.)

On Reddit, where Wright first [shared his tale of woe](#), communities like r/StubHub and r/WorldCup2026 are saturated with antipathy toward ticket resellers; when you type *StubHub* into the Reddit search box, an A.I.-generated description sums up the subreddit’s chatter as “World Cup ticket failures and calls to stop using StubHub.” Sure, some attendees may be [splurging thousands on a single ticket](#), but others are getting nothing at all, even after traveling across international borders for games.

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“When sellers don’t deliver tickets on time, StubHub investigates and takes swift action in line with our terms & conditions, including permanent bans and financial penalties,” a spokesperson for StubHub wrote in a statement to Slate. “The transfer failures fans have encountered stem from performance issues with the [event organizer’s own app infrastructure](#)—a challenge that affects all resale platforms operating at this tournament—and we are trying to engage with the event organizer directly to address it.” According to the spokesperson, “the vast majority of World Cup orders on StubHub have been fulfilled successfully.”

Other buyers would say, however, that such issues long predate the current soccer bonanza. StubHub, which merged with [the controversial](#) British ticket exchange Viagogo in 2020, has been racked with various scandals over the years: paying out a \$10 million federal settlement over [deceptive pricing practices](#), allowing [“speculative tickets”](#) (listings from resellers who do *not* actually

hold the relevant tickets) to run rampant, and retracting high-level sports and concert tickets from consumers [in order to gouge their prices](#) and re-resell them. But the World Cup in particular seems to be exposing the full extent of a problem StubHub has faced during other [large-scale](#) events, like [Zach Bryan](#) and [Taylor Swift tours](#): It's too easy for the system to get overwhelmed with potentially deceitful or inconsistent sellers, along with desperate deal-seekers who don't really know what they're buying, and one company cannot handle all those complaints efficiently—even after [automating much](#) of that support system.

“Nobody’s really solved how to get tickets to clients faster on the secondary side, and it seems like StubHub hasn’t made too much progress, which is disappointing to see,” Taylor Hagstrom, an Atlanta-based customer experience representative who worked with StubHub’s Global Fan Experience team in 2024 and 2025, told me. On that team, Hagstrom took messages (calls, emails, chats) from ticket buyers and collaborated with the company’s sellers division to resolve reports. “All those escalations showed *clearly* that ticket delivery is one of the biggest points of pain for customers, so why not put as much energy behind solving that as possible?”

Hagstrom had to handle consumer escalations for “tough” events, like the Masters and the NFL playoffs, so he had a clear view of where StubHub needed to improve: accelerating the ticket-transfer process and leaving more time to handle potential disputes before an event begins. There are measures the company has adopted over the years to bolster its platform against myriad vulnerabilities: adopting [cybersecurity programs](#) to preempt automated bot accounts, and expanding protections for music festival mishaps. But the list of issues is still long (lack of thorough user verification, [susceptibility to hacks](#), nontransparency around fees), and the fixes are slow, per Hagstrom. “We would work with our various technology teams to try to improve the site. I know they’re trying to make these timelines tighter,” he said, “but the whole place needs to put consumer insights back in their focus.” (After publication, a StubHub spokesperson wrote to Slate that “Primary ticketing companies and event organizers control when tickets are released, directly impacting when they can be transferred. For high-profile events like the World Cup, some tickets are only made available hours before a match starts, which makes transfer more difficult and creates confusion for fans.”)

The World Cup goes until July 19, so unless something drastically changes, and soon, more consumer insights will inevitably pile up for StubHub—in the form of endless and increasingly prominent complaints from buyers who trusted the platform and its sellers with their money. After all, nearly every source I spoke to for this story told me they’ll never use StubHub again.

This piece has been updated with additional comments from StubHub.

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